WebSense Enterprise Server Test Report

Created 07-18-02 Arthur

Summary

WebSense Enterprise Server (abbreviated WS below) is a mature content-filtering product with various configurations. I test the configuration for Microsoft Internet Service Accelerator (abbreviated ISA below). This configuration contains two parts, one is a stand alone server handling server management and HTTP request redirection. The other is a hook to ISA server following standard COM+ interface defined by Microsoft. These two parts interacts with TCP/IP sockets, and thus WS standalone is not required to sit in the same machine with ISA.

WS is strong for its rich categories and category management. It's server management is well done with no fancy GUI. Throughput performance is not measured since ISA can only handle 350 concurrent connections per second, and thus we can't know how fast is WS standalone if throughput is around 350 per second.

They seperate their Report Generator (abbreviated RG below) into other package. I failed to test this package since it can't even be installed.

Test Configuration

Hardware: VMWare Virtual Machine, P4 1.8 GHz, 256MB RAM, 20GB HDD
Platform: Microsoft Windows 2000 Advanced Server SP2, Microsoft Internet Service Accelerator 2000
Target Software: WebSense Enterprise Server 4.40b, WebSense Report Generator 6.5b

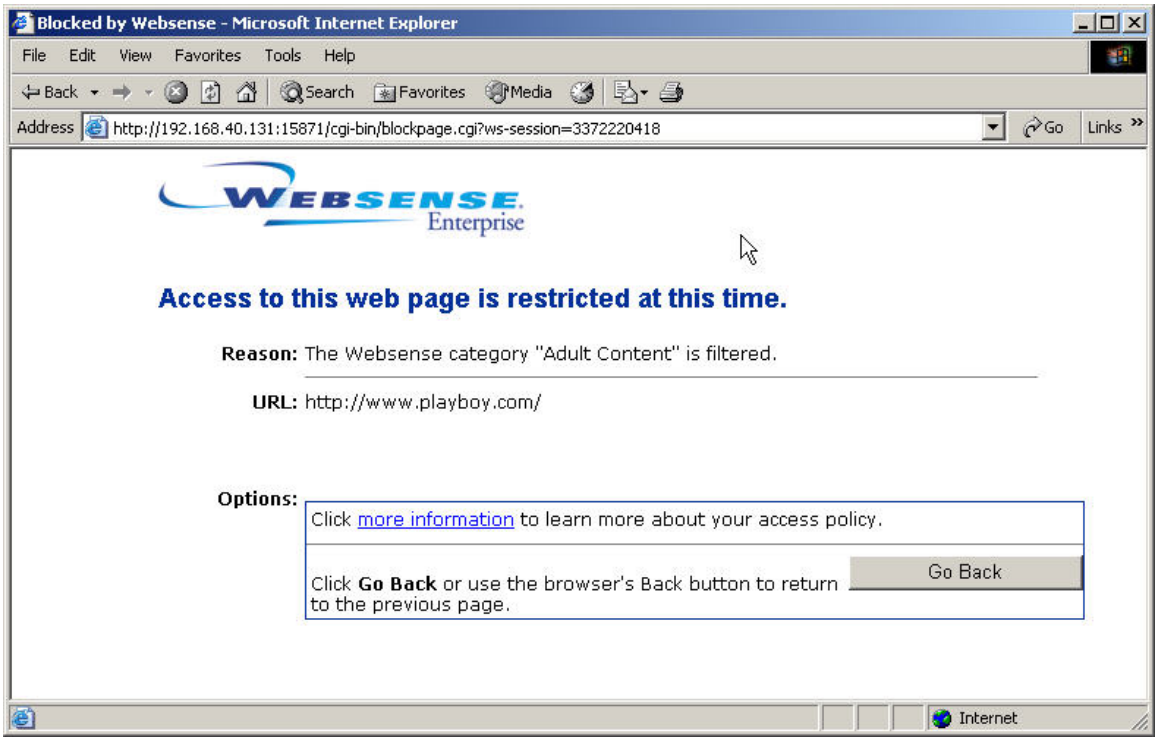
Installation

The installation program of WS is really simple. There are little hints about installation options and thus you MAY get it failed if you have a wrong bet. The installer doesn't detect if there is an ISA server running, either. If you are running WebSense Server, and you run this setup again, it may not be able to handle this situation correctly. In a word, this installer is not tested thoroughly before shipping. The installation guide is too brief to be useful.

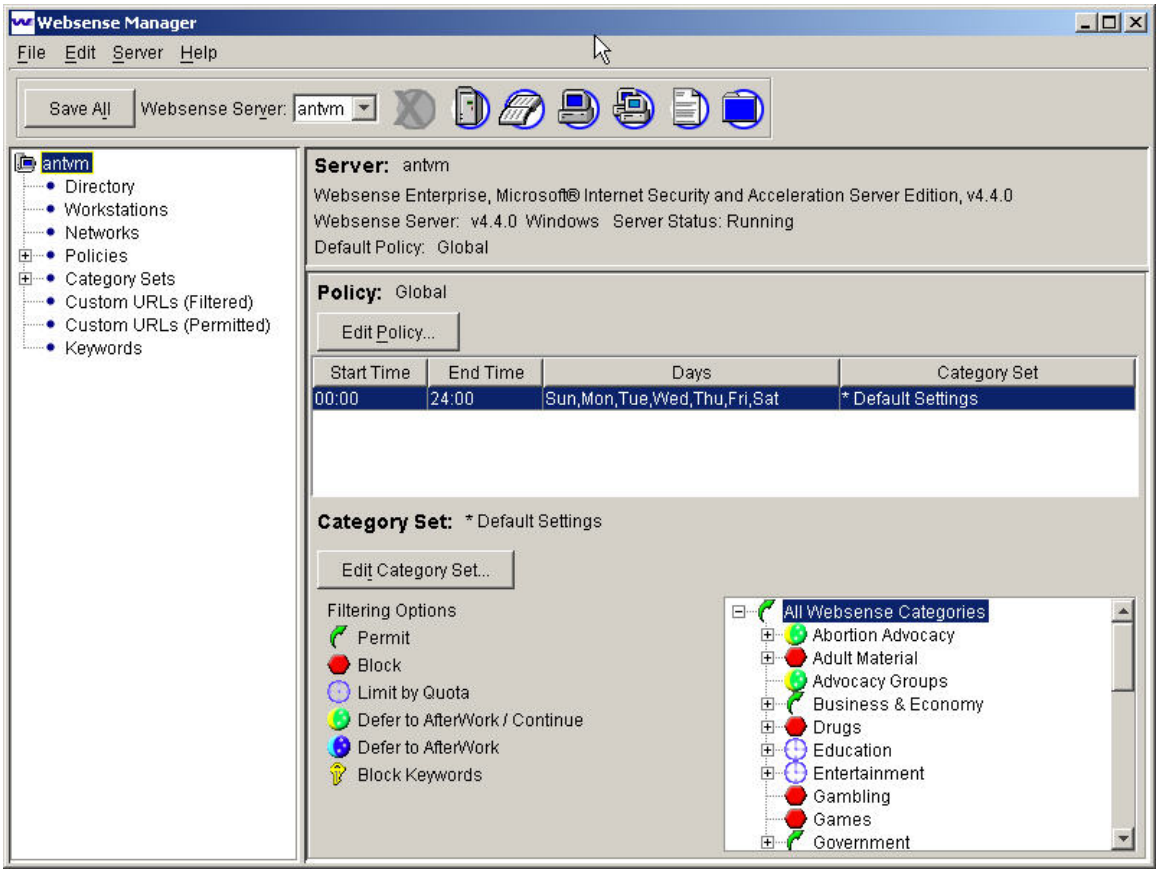
RG's installer is even worse. It tried to install MSDE on your computer, install WebSense Log server, and establish ODBC connections. It screws up the Log server installation part and thus I can't test it. It doesn't detect if WebSense Log Server is running before performing ODBC connection. According to my experience, installation of MSDE database is not an easy job. They should seperate it into two installers.

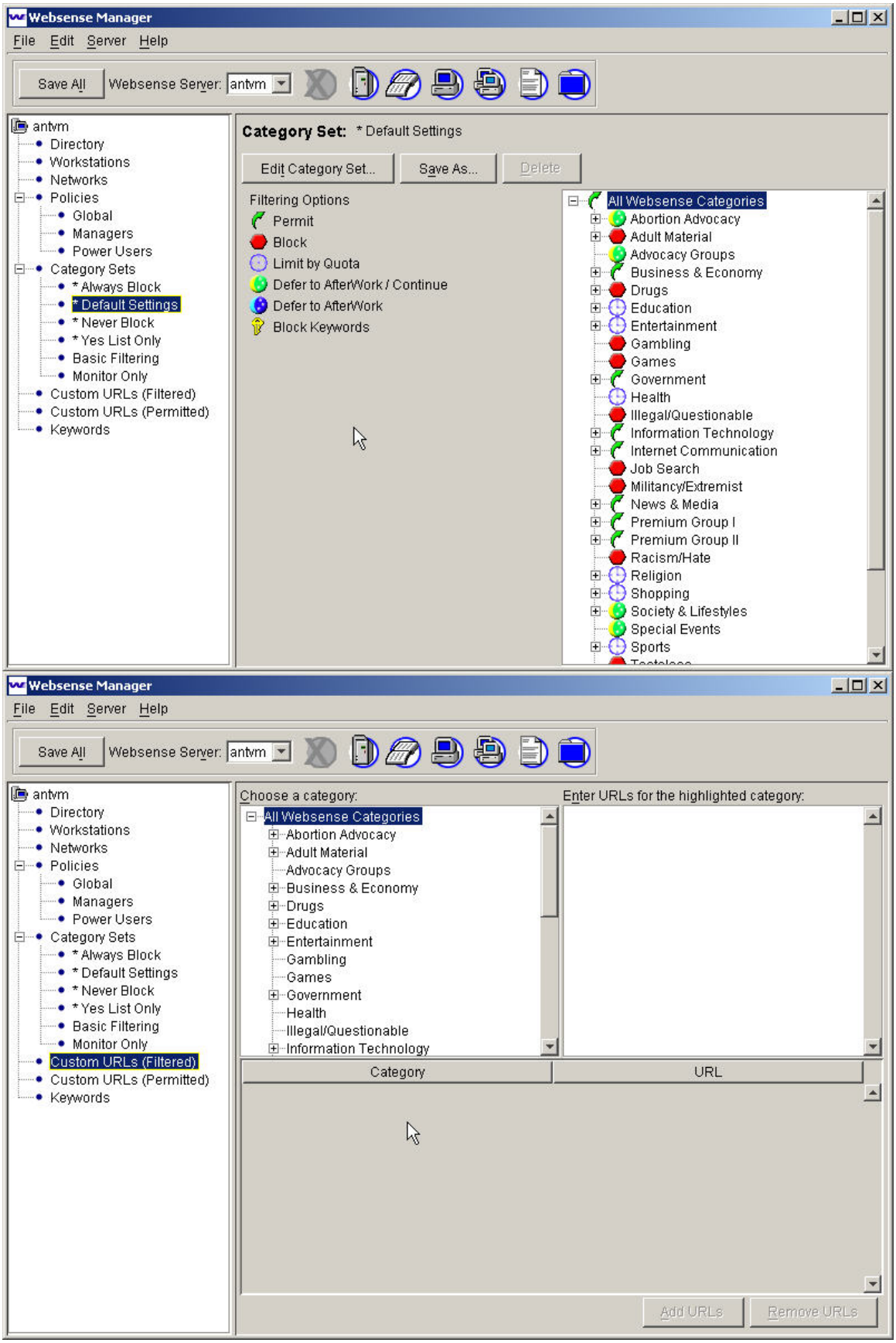
Test Use

After installation of WS you can find it works on your proxy when you try to connect to http://www.playboy.com/.



The WebSense manager screenshot follows.




Websense Manager
File Edit Server Help
Save All
Websense Server: antvm
antvm
Directory
Workstations
Networks
Policies
Global
Managers
Power Users
Category Sets
* Always Block
* Default Settings
* Never Block
* Yes List Only
Basic Filtering
Monitor Only
Custom URLs (Filtered)
Custom URLs (Permitted)
Keywords
Category Set: * Default Settings
Edit Category Set...
Save As...
Delete
Filtering Options
Permit
Block
Limit by Quota
Defer to AfterWork / Continue
Defer to AfterWork
Block Keywords
All Websense Categories
Abortion Advocacy
Adult Material
Advocacy Groups
Business & Economy
Drugs
Education
Entertainment
Gambling
Games
Government
Health
Illegal/Questionable
Information Technology
Internet Communication
Job Search
Militancy/Extremist
News & Media
Premium Group I
Premium Group II
Racism/Hate
Religion
Shopping
Society & Lifestyles
Special Events
Sports
Websense Manager
File Edit Server Help
Save All
Websense Server: antvm
antvm
Directory
Workstations
Networks
Policies
Global
Managers
Power Users
Category Sets
* Always Block
* Default Settings
* Never Block
* Yes List Only
Basic Filtering
Monitor Only
Custom URLs (Filtered)
Custom URLs (Permitted)
Keywords
Choose a category:
Enter URLs for the highlighted category:
All Websense Categories
Abortion Advocacy
Adult Material
Advocacy Groups
Business & Economy
Drugs
Education
Entertainment
Gambling
Games
Government
Health
Illegal/Questionable
Information Technology
Category
URL
Add URLs
Remove URLs

In contradiction to installer, the WS itself is really a serious commercial product and should be admired. WS have a manager program written in Java with an ugly-looking GUI. I think the reason for this design is that they have to run this manager on Solaris, hence they decided to use Java awt as GUI for portability problems. Using this manager is not intuitive owing to both its complexity and lack of hints.

The first thing you'll face to use WS is to download database. They have three download sites for you to choose: America, Asia, and Europe. Database download is scheduled daily from HQ. Initial package contains a 19MB DB, and current DB is 34 MB. This induces a long wait for downloading database. Entries in database are believed to be generated by human eyes and thus can be divided into various categories.

Since there are too many categories there, WS introduces a concept named "Category Set". A category set is a predefined policy, such as "Always Block", "Never Block", or "Default Setting". Local adminstrator can predefine several category sets and then apply them in different time intervals. For example, you can set it to "Never Block" in off hours and "Default Settings" in office hours. Our product is capable of doing this feature but we have only 4 categories by now.

Filtering is also more sophiscated than merely block or pass. They have three defer options to choose: "Limit by Quota", "Defer to Afterwork/Continue", and "Defer to AfterWork/Block". WS also provide keyword filtering for the URL itself (not the content). Our product do not have this feature yet, and if we want to add this feature, it will be a major design change since we have to change tag masks.

Site filter control have three levels: "Global", "Manager Override", and "Power User Neglect". We do not design the "Power User Neglect" feature in our product. It can be done with API modifications, and we have to contriant the number of power users.